FOR-AND-AGAINST ESSAYS

Writing arguments

Steps in writing arguments

1. Think about the topic at hand and make a list of possible arguments
2. Analyse your list and choose at least 2 arguments for and 2 arguments against.
3. Write down a first draft of an argument.
4. Refine your argument into its finished form.

Step 1 – Making a list

- When beginning to list the arguments, think about the topic at hand from different viewpoints and perspectives.
- If you get stuck, you can always try to use S.P.E.R.M. and go through each perspective, writing down new potential arguments as you think of them.
- Remember, you don’t have to use each argument you write down, so don’t worry whether a potential argument is good or bad or whether you can explain it. You’ll worry about that later. For now, just write them down.

S.P.E.R.M.

- **Social** – does the issue raised by the topic affect people from different social classes or background differently (rich people vs. Poor people, young people vs. Old people,…)
- **Political** – is there a political issue related to the topic at hand?
- **Economical** – does the issue raised by the topic have a significant economic impact on people or society?
- **Research** – how does the topic at hand affect technology, or is it possibly somehow affected by technology?
- **Moral** – are there any moral/ethical questions which are raised by the topic?

- **REMEMBER: Don't spend too much time on writing down a list of arguments. This should take you some 5-8 minutes to do.**

Step 2 – checking the list (and checking it twice)

- Once you have list of potential arguments, you now need to choose at least 2 arguments from each side (for AND against) which you will present in your essay.
- There really is no science to this. But there are several guidelines which you should follow for this step:
    - Remember that it's better to have fewer well-explained arguments than a whole bunch of poorly reasoned arguments.
    - A lot of perspectives on a topic have both a positive and a negative side to them. Try to find those perspective because they can give you 2 arguments for „the price" of one.
    - Only choose those arguments that you can explain why they're important.
- REMEMBER: Like with thinking of possible arguments, don't spend too much time here. Once you have 2 arguments for each side, you should be ready to give up choosing more if you get stuck. You still have the hardest steps to do, so mind the time.

Step 3 – First draft

- Each argument consists of two parts:
  - **Stating the argument;** **Explaining the argument**
- When writing an argument down, write something down – no matter how simple a sentence. Write something down. Remember, it's only a first draft. You'll fix it later.

- Let's take a quick example argument for school uniforms:

  School uniforms promote euqality (this is us stating the argument)*. They make students look equal* (this is us explaining why the argument is relevant)*.*

- Let's be clear. This argument is horribly written. But right this moment it isn't that important. What's important now is that we have AN argument written down. We will fix it in the next step.

Step 4 – Refining and revision

- In this (most important step in writing an argument) we actually refine our argument into something we can put in our final version of our essay. We do this by going back to our first draft and choosing the correct vocabulary, phrases, and sentence structures, putting in the correct linkers.
- In general, this where we're making our argument presentable.

- Let's look back at our first draft

Refining and revision - example

ORIGINAL: *School uniforms promote euqality. They make students look equal.*

First of all, it is claimed that school uniforms promote equality among students because the uniforms' identical appearance makes students look equal by hiding their own clothes, which may reflect the socio-economic status.

- This linker sets our argument within the entire paragraph (it is our first argument for).
- The impersonal report structure makes the sentence more objective (since it's not us saying this, but rather someone else).
- These comments are added for clarity. The first one to show that the equality applies only to students (and not to someone else). The second makes it clearer who the subject of the sentence is.
- This conjunction gives a clear „cause-and-effect" between the two former sentences (now clauses because the conjunction connects the two sentences into one).
- We need to add an –*s* here to follow the subject-verb agreement rule.
- *This clause further explains the argument by giving us a practical reason to explain an abstract concept.*

Ending revision

- Once you have done this process for all of your arguments, you have successfully written the body of your essay.

- Again, whether you'll write down a first draft for all your arguments first, or you'll work and work on one argument before moving on to the next one is up to you. You need to choose how you proceed here. Each person is different in this regard.